

States was rapidly becoming the world's largest industrial power. In 1880, Britain was still producing more steel than the United States, but by 1900 the United States was producing more steel than Britain and Germany together.

At the same time, steam-powered ships were also being introduced. Sailing times, no longer dependent on the vagaries of the wind, became more controllable, and journey times were shortened. The ships were significantly larger, too. While the largest wooden ships rarely exceeded 200 ft (60 m) in length, the *Great Eastern*, launched in 1858, was 689 ft (210 m) long. Total world steamship tonnage in 1870 was 1.4 million. By 1910, it had reached 19 million.

Winners and losers

The benefits of industrialization were unevenly spread. Southern Europe was slow to react to it, and Russia also struggled to catch up. The Chinese and Indian empires proved unwilling or unable to industrialize,

Latin America did so only intermittently, and Africa was dominated by technologically superior powers. By contrast, after 1868, Japan's single-minded pursuit of industrialization made it a world power.

Industrialization also made possible a new kind of warfare, one capable of bringing death on a scale never seen before. An enduring irony of industrialization is that the nations that benefited most from it turned it against themselves in two world wars, deploying weapons of extraordinarily destructive power.

The Industrial Revolution laid the foundations for the modern world. Fueled by an enormous sense of new possibilities, in some places it raised living standards across all sections of society in ways unimaginable in earlier ages. However, in the wealthy West, it also produced a sense that material superiority was equivalent to a kind of moral superiority, one that not merely made it possible for the West to dominate the world, but demanded that it do so. ■

